and were threatening Thembang was obviously the main topic of discussion. Gurbax had suggested to Pathania that in light of the Chinese move, both 62 and 65 Brigade should immediately withdraw to Bomdila from where the entire divisional resource could be brought into play to halt the Chinese. Gurbax at the time was not aware of the Chinese having attacked Nuranang already. When Pathania told him that the Garhwalis had been fighting since the morning, Gurbax suggested that HQ 4 Division along with 65 Infantry Brigade should fall back, leaving 62 Brigade to fight the Chinese at Se-la. From a tactical point of view, under the circumstances, the second scenario made some sense; however, the suggestion was not acceptable to Pathania.

In between the two telephone conversations (first with Gurbax Singh and then with Hoshiar Singh) Pathania had dispatched his layout party to head for Tenga where he hoped to establish his Division HQ.

On seeing the party leave hurriedly, word spread through Division HQ and the administrative troops that the GOC was planning ‘to do a bunk’. However, Hoshiar Singh, at Se-la, was unaware of these developments. His reluctance to ask the covering troops to withdraw from what had proved to be tactically an extremely well sited position was understandable. General Pathania would later claim that by the time he spoke to Brigadier Hoshiar Singh at 3.30 p.m., the latter had already withdrawn 4 Garhwal Rifles, ordered 4 Sikh LI to fall back on to the main Se-la defences and that Hoshiar Singh had asked the GOC to retrospectively sanction his decision.

This testimony was false. On the contrary, Pathania in his conversation with Hoshiar Singh had said that IV Corps had ordained that ‘on no account the covering troops were to be sacrificed by delaying their withdrawal in face of superior build up’. Hence, despite his better judgement, Hoshiar Singh withdrew 4 Garhwal Rifles from Nuranang at around 4 p.m., roughly around the time the last Chinese assault was being beaten back. By then, owing to Chinese shelling, the communication lines between 62 Brigade and 4 Garhwal Rifles had snapped and hence Captain Abraham of 4 Sikh LI and another officer were physically sent with the message for Lieutenant Colonel Bhattacharjea.

In his message, Hoshiar congratulated the battalion commander and his officers and men for ‘a very steady and defensive battle’. He also gave instructions for redeploying the battalion. They were to abandon the present defences so as to cross KM 108 on the Jang–Se-la–Bomdila road latest by